Minutes of the
General Government Committee Meeting
2023 Operating Budget and 2023 Capital Budget; 2024-2032 Long Range Capital Forecast
Held Electronically at 9:00 a.m. on February 16, 2023

Alternative formats available upon request by contacting:
accessibility@ajax.ca or 905-619-2529 ext. 3347

Present:	Chair – Mayor	S. Collier
	Regional Councillors	M. Crawford
		S. Lee
		J. Dies
	Councillors	R. Tyler Morin
		N. Henry
		L. Bower

1. Call to Order & Acknowledgement of Traditional Treaty Lands

Chair – Mayor Collier called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. and acknowledged traditional treaty lands.

2. Disclosure of Pecuniary Interest

There were no disclosures of pecuniary interest.

3. Mayor's Opening Comments

Mayor Collier, Budget Chair, provided opening comments, thanked staff for their hard work on the preparation of the 2023 Operating Budget and 2023 Capital Budget; 2024 – 2032 Long Range Capital Forecast, and reviewed highlights of the proposed budget.

4. Reports Requiring Direction

4.1 FIN-2023-02: Capital Reserve Status Report

Committee Members asked questions regarding the Town's building portfolio namely facility usage and condition, building naming rights eligibility, opportunities to utilize existing infrastructure to assist the unhoused population, status of the review of underutilized Town facilities and building appraisals, debenture financing and leasing options for vehicle and equipment, and remedies to address the infrastructure funding gap. Dianne Valentim, Director of Finance/Treasurer, Kassandra Cruciano, Senior Advisor, Grants, Partnerships & Strategic Initiatives, Geoff Romanowski, Director of Planning & Development Services, Samuel Twumasi, Manager of Economic Development, and Dave Meredith, Director of Operations & Environmental Services, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Move by: L. Bower

That Council approve the implementation of a 2% infrastructure levy in the 2023 Operating Budget.

CARRIED

4.2 PDS-2023-03: Stormwater Funding Implementation Strategy

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for a proposed flat fee vs. a mill rate, objective of a stormwater management system, stormwater funding, and stormwater-related charges among other municipalities. D. Valentim, G. Romanowski, and Stephen Ruddy, Manager of Development Engineering, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Moved by: S. Lee

1. That Council approve the Stormwater Funding Implementation Strategy as outlined in this report, and

2. That Staff develop, in consultation with non-residential stakeholders, a Stormwater Fee Credit Policy to be implemented concurrently with the Stormwater Fee.

CARRIED

5. Capital Budget

5.1 Capital Budget Presentation

D. Valentim delivered a presentation on the 2023 Capital Budget and 2024 – 2032 Long Range Capital Forecast.

D. Valentim provided an overview of the Town's capital budget and 2024– 2032 long range capital forecast and discussed process/timelines, capital budget funding, the Financial Sustainability Plan, and capital reserve allocations. D. Valentim reviewed the 2023 Draft Capital Budget including capital project funding, capital budget considerations, project numbering, capital project maps, capital budget reserve assumptions, stormwater reserve user fees, Canada Community-Building Fund details, and concluded the presentation with a review of multi-year/pre-budget approval projects and the new infrastructure levy.

Committee Members asked questions regarding the sustainability of the Canada Community-Building Fund given increased use in electric vehicles and inquired about the status of the Library report. D. Valentim and Sarah Vaisler, Chief Librarian and Executive Officer, responded to questions from Committee Members. D. Valentim noted that the Ajax Public Library Grant is covered under the operating budget.

5.2 Review of Budget

5.2.2. 2023 Capital Budget; 2024 – 2032 Long Range Capital Forecast

Chair Collier led the Committee through a section-by-section review of the proposed 2023 Capital Budget and 2024 – Long Range Capital Forecast. Questions and discussion focused primarily upon the following projects:

Project List

Studies and Other Initiatives

24000701 Traffic Calming Warrant Update 2025

Committee Members asked questions regarding project scope, timelines, and current traffic calming measures. G. Romanowski and Dhaval Pandya, Manager of Transportation Planning, responded to questions from Committee Members. G. Romanowski reviewed ongoing measures to support traffic calming.

23090101 Official Plan Review

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for increased project costs, project timelines and requirements under the Planning Act, opportunities to accelerate the Official Plan (OP) Review, project scope, and if the proposed business plans will accelerate the OP Review. Stev Andis, Manager of Planning and G. Romanowski, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Technology

23001801 Human Resource Mgmt System (HRMS)

Committee Members asked questions regarding increased project costs, project scope, benefits to the organization, popularity of a similar system among other private or public organizations, scope of the Customer Relationship Management System project, IT Strategy framework, and opportunities for revenue savings and efficiencies. Nicole Cooper, Director of Legislative & Information Services/Clerk, Chris Walker, Manager of Technology & Innovation, and D. Valentim, responded

to questions from Committee Members. C. Walker provided an overview of the system, noting that the centralized system would be leveraged by all Business Departments and that the project was identified as part of the IT Strategic Plan.

23003801 Radio System Hardware Upgrade

Committee Members asked questions regarding project scope, project rationale, project costs, coordination with NextGen Radio System, and if the system upgrade was identified in the Fire Master Plan. Aaron Burridge, Interim Fire Chief, responded to questions from Committee Members.

23010306 OLA Replacement

Committee Members asked questions regarding project rationale, content housed on OLA, project alignment with the new HRMS, and project timelines, noting that the project was not forecasted historically. Devon Jarvis, Supervisor of Communications & Engagement and C. Walker, responded to questions from Committee Members. D. Jarvis noted that the current Intranet site is outdated and highlighted inadequacies of the current Intranet platform.

Amendment

Moved by: S. Lee

That capital project 23010306: OLA Replacement be deferred to 2024 for consideration in future capital budgets.

CARRIED

23010301 JDE Upgrade

Committee Members asked questions regarding project scope and opportunities for integration with HRMS. C. Walker responded to questions from Committee Members.

26010302 Anti Virus (EDR) Software Upgrade
27010301 Firewall Upgrade

Committee Members asked questions regarding upgrade frequency and technology infrastructure management processes. C. Walker and D. Valentim, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Town Buildings

23000401 Rotary Park Pavilion - Feasibility Study
25000301 St. Andrews Feasibility Study – RPMP

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for the studies, scope of work to be completed under the Recreation & Parks Master Plan and the Waterfront Management Plan, project timelines, capital budget allocation for Pickering Village Arena, timelines associated with a Request for Proposal (RFP) for the Pickering Village Arena site, status of improvements to St. Andrews Community Centre, construction timelines, and seniors centre models. D. Meredith and Chris Vida, Director of Recreation & Culture, responded to questions from Committee Members.

23000301 Demo-Greenwood House/Barn/Flats/Washrm

Committee Members expressed concerns regarding project costs given that the Town does not own the property or the building. Committee Members asked questions regarding opportunities for additional parking at Greenwood House and opportunities to offload the facility to the Region of Durham. D. Meredith noted that the Town owns the building, and reviewed project scope and rationale.

23070402 MCC Community Room 2 Renovations

Committee Members sought clarification regarding which room is Community Room 2 and questioned the necessary timing of the project this year, noting that it was not forecasted historically. C. Vida noted that Community Room 1 is offline and unavailable for Town programming or rental.

23070901 Roof Repl Rotary Park, Hartrick and Quaker

Committee Members asked questions regarding project costs, infrastructure impacts resulting from deferred maintenance, opportunities to separate the projects, discretionary funds, and project timelines. D. Meredith and C. Vida, responded to questions from Committee Members. D. Valentim noted that the Town can fund emergency repairs but noted that this process does not support good procurement practices.

Amendment

Moved by: S. Collier

That capital project 23070901 Roof Repl Rotary Park, Hartrick and Quaker be deferred to 2024 for consideration in future capital budgets pending the completion of appraisals and various related studies.

MOTION LOST

24001501 Fire HQ - Outdoor Training Shelter

Committee Members asked questions regarding project scope and opportunities for a shared training shelter throughout Durham Region. Interim Fire Chief Burridge responded to questions from Committee Members.

23070303 ACC Main Lobby Elevator Refurbishment
24000301 ACC Rec Master Plan Renovation

Committee Members expressed concerns related to accessibility issues and barriers. Committee Members asked questions regarding project costs, project timelines, opportunities to secure a new building rather than renovating the existing facility, and feasibility of ongoing facility maintenance. C. Vida and D. Meredith, responded to questions from Committee Members.

31000201 Operation Centre - Curtain Wall Upgrades

Committee Members asked questions regarding project scope and rationale. D. Meredith responded to questions from Committee Members.

23010101 Town Hall Service & Parking Lot Rehab

Committee Members expressed concerns regarding parking lot design namely obstructed views and asked if a concept plan is coming forward. D. Meredith discussed components of the project and highlighted speeding and accessibility issues.

23090202 Fire Station 2 Renovations (FMP)

Committee Members asked questions regarding costs associated with a new facility vs. renovating the existing facility, project timelines, projected cost increases, sustainability, and capital funding options namely opportunities to debenture the project. Interim Fire Chief Burridge, D. Meredith, and D. Valentim, responded to questions from Committee Members. D. Valentim noted that the project is funded through development charges.

Parks & Open Spaces

23070009 Cedar Park Batting Cage

Committee Members expressed concerns regarding project costs and asked questions regarding project scope, project demand, revenue generation, proposed location and highway 401 corridor impacts, and cost-effective project alternatives. D. Meredith provided rationale for increased project costs, and discussed project scope and project timelines.

Amendment

Moved by: S. Lee

That capital project 230070009 - Cedar Park Batting Cage be deferred to 2026 for consideration in future capital budgets.

MOTION LOST

1029711 Meadows North Neigh Park

Committee Members asked questions regarding project scope, project funding, location, and opportunities to bring in servicing infrastructure to accommodate a waterpark. D. Valentim noted that the project is funded through development charges. D. Meredith responded to questions from Committee Members.

23000801 North Ajax - Cricket Infrastructure

Committee Members asked questions regarding project completion timelines and project costs. D. Meredith responded to questions from Committee Members.

Committee recessed at 12:20 p.m.

Committee resumed at 1:00 p.m.

23070005 Exeter Park – Park Retrofit
1036311 Millers Creek Trail (MCC) Rec
1036111 Trail Recon – Hermitage Park

Committee Members sought rationale for the retrofits and project timelines. D. Meredith provided rationale for the retrofits and identified maintenance and repair priorities.

Committee Members asked staff to include detail sheets for all capital projects in the future to provide additional context.

Vehicles & Equipment

23003001 Multi-use Tractor with Implements
23090305 Articulated/Sidewalk Tractor w/Brine/Plow
23003101 Blvd Grounds Maint Equip-pend new staff appr

Committee Members expressed concerns regarding procurement costs. Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for the equipment purchases, equipment functions, and staff resources. D. Meredith provided rationale for procurement of the equipment noting that additional resources are required to assist with winter control operations. D. Meredith noted that the equipment has already received pre-budget approval.

23090501 Library Collection - Growth – 2023

Committee Members asked why this item is included in the capital budget rather than the Library Grant. D. Valentim noted that the project is funded through development charges.

23000701 Bike Counters

Committee Members asked questions regarding project rationale. G. Romanowski noted that bike counters are recommended under the Town's Integrated Transportation Master Plan and the Town could be eligible for future grant funding.

23070112 Holiday Decorations 2023

Committee Members asked questions regarding project costs, life cycle, and display period. D. Meredith noted that some of the decorations have exceeded their life cycle and require replacement.

23070205 ACC Floor Machines

Committee Members sought clarification regarding the number of floor machines being procured. C. Vida noted that the floor machines have exceeded their life cycle and require replacement.

Committee Members sought rationale for why there isn't a detail sheet for each capital project. D. Valentim and S. Baker noted that staff will look to improve the budget process for next year.

23002301 Accommodation Strategy-Workstation Modification

Committee Members asked questions regarding project rationale, project scope, proposed work model, impacts if the project is deferred to 2024, opportunities to separate the project into phases, furniture disposal and recycling options, scope of work to be completed in the Office of the CAO, funding, and accommodation needs for employees working remotely. D. Valentim, K. Cruciano, G. Romanowski, S. Baker, and N. Cooper, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Road Network

23003601 Harwood MUP - Falby Ct. to Clover Ridge Dr.
23090312 Harwood Bike Lane - Falby to Westney
23090313 Harwood (E Side) MUT - Bayly to Falby

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for the phased project approach, rationale for inclusion of on-road bike lanes and a multi-use path along the Harwood corridor, detailed design, increased costs, and timelines associated with the implementation of cycling infrastructure in North Ajax. G. Romanowski and D. Meredith, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Mayor Collier noted that Council passed a motion in October 2021 directing staff to proceed with detailed design of an off-road multi-use path (on the east side of Harwood Avenue) instead of the proposed on-road active transportation facilities as recommended in the 2012 Lower Harwood Study and 2019 Integrated Transportation Master Plan.

Amendment

Moved by: S. Collier

That capital project 23090312 Harwood Bike Lane – Falby to Westney be removed from the capital budget.

CARRIED

23090320 Harwood (W Side) Bike Lane-Bayly to Falby

Committee Members asked if this segment is associated with project 23090313 Harwood (E Side) MUT - Bayly to Falby. G. Romanowski responded to the question from Committee Members.

23090318 Stannardville Bike Lane - Rossland to Hurst
23090319 Hurst Bike Lane - Stannardville to Church

Committee Members sought clarification on the necessary timing of the projects this year. D. Valentim noted that the projects are funded through development charges. G. Romanowski provided rationale for timing of the projects.

1029011 Rossland Wide Salem/LakeRidge
1028611 Rossland Wide Westney-Salem

Committee Members asked questions regarding funding sources, project status, project timelines, timelines associated with the tendering process and land acquisition process, detailed design, and funding sources. D. Meredith noted that the detailed design has been awarded for Rossland Road from Westney Road to Lake Ridge Road. D. Meredith, G. Romanowski, and D. Valentim, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Traffic Signal Light Replacements

Committee Members sought clarification regarding who is responsible for traffic signal light replacements. D. Meredith advised that unwarranted signals are the responsibility of the lower tier municipality.

Bridges & Culverts

23030402 Municipal Bridge Inspections

Committee Members asked if municipal bridge inspections are part of the asset allocation study. D. Meredith noted that it is a legislative requirement to inspect bridges and culverts every two (2) years.

Stormwater Network

23001401 Waterfront Rain Garden – Construction

Committee Members sought clarification on the necessary timing of the project this year. S. Ruddy responded to the question from Committee Members. D. Valentim noted that the project is funded through the Canada Community-Build Fund.

Summary of New Capital Projects by Driver

Committee Members had no comments or questions on this section of the capital budget document.

Financing Summaries

Committee Members had no comments or questions on this section of the capital budget document.

Continuity Schedules

Committee Members had no comments or questions on this section of the capital budget document.

5.3 **Public Comments & Questions**

Chair Collier invited comments and questions from the public on the proposed 2023 Capital Budget and 2024 **–** 2032 Long Range Capital Forecast.

There were no questions or comments from the public.

Committee Members and Chair Collier thanked staff for their hard work in preparing the 2023 Capital Budget and 2024-2032 Long Range Capital Forecast.

5.2 **Review of Budget**

5.2.1. **FIN-2023-03: 2023 Capital Budget; 2024 – 2032 Long Range Capital Forecast**

Final Recommendations, as Amended:

Moved by: R. Tyler Morin

1. That the following 2023 General Levy Funded Reserve Allocations be approved:

Reserve	
Building Maintenance	$889,700
Election	81,000
Post Build Out	113,300
Development	200,000
Strategic Initiatives	387,000
Roads Maintenance	1,815,300
General Infrastructure Maintenance	973,300
Vehicle and Equipment	1,657,900
Total Allocations	**$6,117,500**

2. That the 2023 Capital Budget in the amount of $28,670,900 be approved, as amended;

3. That revenue collected from the new Stormwater User Fee in the estimated amount of $2,670,000 be transferred to the Stormwater Maintenance Reserve;

4. That the 2024 – 2032 Long Range Capital Forecast be received for information.

CARRIED

Recorded Vote

In Favour: Regional Councillor Lee, Councillor Bower, Regional Councillor Crawford, Regional Councillor Dies, Councillor Henry, Councillor Tyler Morin, Mayor Collier

Opposed: None

Committee recessed at 3:04 p.m.

Committee resumed at 3:21 p.m.

6. Operating Budget

6.1 Operating Budget Presentation

D. Valentim delivered a presentation on the 2023 Operating Budget.

D. Valentim provided an overview of the Town's operating budget including process and timelines for development of the budget. D. Valentim discussed the budget framework, operating budget overview, the Library Grant, operating budget impacts and pressures, Public Health Reserve, stormwater fee impacts on the residential tax bill, Bill 23, More Homes Built Faster Act, 2022 impacts, expenditures by source, revenues by source, operating budget outlook, and tax calculation.

Committee Members asked questions regarding the portion of taxation revenues and impacts to residents on the property tax bill. D. Valentim responded to questions from Committee Members. S. Baker noted that the Town looks to increase non-tax revenues year over year to ease the tax burden.

6.2 Review of Budget

6.2.2. 2023 Operating Budget

Chair Collier led the Committee through a section-by-section review of the proposed 2023 Operating Budget.

Section 3: Business Cases

Digital Graphic Designer

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for the cost / benefit analysis outlined in the business case. D. Jarvis provided an overview of costs associated with the position and noted that the salary also reflects current pay of the contract position.

Labour Relations Specialist

Committee Members asked if this position is currently a contracted position and asked questions regarding payroll administration and costs associated with contracted services vs. in-house services. Mary Lou Cosentino, Manager of HR Services and S. Baker, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Financial Analyst (Development Accounting)

Committee Members asked questions regarding future staffing needs to support development growth and if the position is exempt or non-exempt. D. Valentim and G. Romanowski, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Summer Student – Finance

Committee Members asked questions regarding opportunities for grant funding or apprenticeship programs. D. Valentim and Christie McLardie, Manager of Public & Strategic Affairs, responded to questions from Committee Members.

By-law Services Associate & Waterfront Admin Support

Committee Members sought clarification regarding rationale for the positions. N. Cooper provided justifications for the positions, noting that the parking enforcement and permitting programs generate non-tax revenues for the Town, which offset the cost of these programs and contribute to the recovery of the cost of the positions.

HRMS – Business Solutions Specialist

Committee Members asked if the position would contribute to payroll efficiencies. S. Baker responded to the question from Committee Members.

Environmental Service Workers – Special Events

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for the number of positions, costs, opportunities for portable stage rentals, and collective agreement restrictions. D. Meredith and D. Valentim, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Operations Technologist – Technical Services and Maintenance Contracts

Committee Members asked questions regarding customer service / engagement complaints, expected customer service benefits, and functions of the position. D. Meredith responded to questions from Committee Members.

Crossing Guard Supervisor

Committee Members asked questions regarding crossing guard shortages, crossing guard program costs, service delivery adopted by the City of Pickering, costs for contracted services, and portfolio and function of the position. D. Meredith responded to questions from Committee Members.

Fleet and Inventory Supervisor

Committee Members sought clarification regarding the necessary timing of the business case. D. Meredith provided rationale for the position and reviewed functions of the position.

Borehole & Geotechnical Reporting

Committee Members asked if this position was historically a contracted position and sought clarification regarding the business case. D. Meredith responded to the question from Committee Members, noting that the position is currently a contracted service.

PT Facility Booking Representative

Committee Members asked questions regarding rationale for the position, expanded service hours, revenue projections, and service levels. C. Vida reviewed the business case and noted that Town facilities are understaffed and overutilized.

Recreation Facilities – Contracted Security

Committee Members expressed concerns regarding costs associated with the business case. Committee Members asked questions regarding roving services, opportunities to share contracted security services with the Ajax Public Library, and limitations imposed on security guards. C. Vida reviewed expected benefits and service impacts. S. Vaisler noted that the Ajax Public Library partners with Recreation & Culture for security services when needed.

Festivals & Events Coordinator

Committee Members asked if this is a new position. C. Vida responded to questions from Committee Members and noted that the position was pre-approved prior to the pandemic and has been re-introduced into the 2023 capital budget.

Energy & Sustainability Coordinator

Committee Members asked questions regarding justifications for the position. G. Romanowski and Cameron Richardson, Supervisor of Environmental Sustainability & Climate Change, provided rationale and justifications for the position.

Section 2: Department Summaries

Members provided questions and comments on the following sections within the proposed 2023 Operating Budget:

- **All Departments (p. 12):** Committee Members asked questions regarding Library surplus and the Library Reserve Policy namely allocation of surplus monies to the Town. S. Vaisler noted that the Library has not completed the 2022 year-end closing however estimates a forecasted surplus of $352,000. S. Vaisler further noted that surplus monies in excess of $250,000 are payable to the Town.

- **Mayor and Council (p.15):** Committee Members asked if the 'Mayor's HMS Ajax & River Plate Veterans Association visit to Normandy, France re: Anniversary of D-Day' is still scheduled given economic pressures. Mayor Collier noted that he will not be attending.

- **Finance (p.29):** Committee Members asked questions regarding staff resources in the Finance Department. D. Valentim provided a comparative analysis, reviewed functions of the Finance Department, and noted that the Finance Department supports growth across the organization.

- **Fire & Emergency Services – Administration (p.43):** Committee Members sought clarification regarding items that qualify as 'one-time purchases under $10,000'. Interim Fire Chief Burridge provided an explanation and examples.

- **Operational & Environmental Services - Environmental Services (p. 51)**: Committee Members asked questions regarding contract services. D. Meredith provided an overview of contracted services.

6.3 **Public Comments & Questions**

Chair Collier invited comments and questions from the public on the proposed 2023 Operating Budget.

There were no questions or comments from the public.

Committee Members and Chair Collier thanked staff for their hard work in preparing the 2023 Operating Budget.

6.2 **Review of Budget**

6.2.1. **FIN-2023-04: 2023 Operating Budget**

Moved by: S. Collier

1. That the 2023 Net Operating Budget in the amount of $87,884,200 be approved;

2. That the amount of $86,081,800 be set as the General tax levy for 2023.

CARRIED

Recorded Vote

In Favour: Regional Councillor Lee, Councillor Bower, Regional Councillor Crawford, Regional Councillor Dies, Councillor Henry, Councillor Tyler Morin, Mayor Collier

Opposed: None

7. Adjournment (5:02 p.m.)

Moved by: M. Crawford

That the February 16, 2023 meeting of the General Government Committee Operating Budget and Capital Budget Meeting be adjourned.

CARRIED